Inference from Details - Study Guide

Use clues in the text to reach the smallest conclusion that the evidence actually supports.

Learning goal	Combine details to infer an unstated idea about a person, event, setting, or situation - and reject answers that are merely possible.

Inference is evidence plus reasoning

An inference is not a guess. It is an idea the text does not state directly but supports strongly enough for a careful reader to reach. Strong inference questions often require two or more clues, not one isolated word.

The safest inference is usually the smallest one that explains the evidence. If a text shows a worker checking a forecast, moving supplies indoors, and closing a window, you may infer that the worker expects bad weather. You cannot automatically infer that a hurricane is coming.

Answer type	What it does	How to treat it
Directly stated	Repeats a fact from the text	Correct only if the question asks for that fact; an inference question usually asks for more.
Supported inference	Connects clues without adding unsupported facts	Best choice.
Plausible guess	Could happen in real life but needs extra assumptions	Reject.
Contradiction	Conflicts with a text detail	Reject.

Question language to recognize

- What can the reader most reasonably infer about ___?
- Which conclusion about ___ is best supported by these details?

- Which sentence best supports the inference that ___?
- The passage suggests that ___ is likely to ___ because...

A reliable method

1. Collect two or more relevant clues.
2. State the smallest idea that explains those clues.
3. Check every important word in your inference. If one word is too strong, the whole option may fail.
4. Compare the strongest distractor: does it require outside knowledge, a motive the text never gives, or a prediction that goes too far?

Possible is not enough	Ask: "Would I still believe this if I knew only what the passage tells me?" If the answer depends on a personal assumption, it is not a strong text-based inference.

Worked example

Example	Rina arrived at the meeting ten minutes early. She placed printed copies of the agenda at every seat, tested the projector, and opened the presentation to the first slide. When another student offered to help, Rina handed him a list of names and asked him to check attendance as people entered.

1. What can the reader most reasonably infer about Rina?

A. She dislikes working with other people

B. She is preparing carefully for the meeting

C. She is the oldest person in the group

D. She has never used a projector before

Answer: B	Several actions - arriving early, arranging materials, testing equipment, and delegating attendance - support the idea that she is preparing carefully. The other choices add unsupported facts.

Common traps

- A statement that is reasonable in real life but not supported by the passage.
- A directly stated detail that does not answer the inference question.
- An inference with one exaggerated word such as always, never, definitely, or hates.
- A choice that fits one clue but conflicts with another.

Quick check

Mini text	After the last customer left, Malik counted the cash drawer twice, photographed the final total, and sent the photo to the store manager before locking the drawer.

1. What can the reader reasonably infer about Malik?

A. He is trying to leave a clear record of the closing total

B. He believes the store will close permanently

C. He is hiding the amount of money

D. He has never counted cash before

Answer: A. The repeated count and photo create a documented record; the other options require assumptions.